

Annotated Bibliography: "A Bright Line That Binds on Few: The NBA's 65-Game Rule and Star Availability"

TL;DR

- The theoretical spine of the paper — the notch/bunching methodology (Kleven-Waseem, Saez, Chetty et al.), tournament-incentive theory (Lazear-Rosen, Ehrenberg-Bognanno), and superstar externalities (Rosen, Hausman-Leonard, Kaplan) — is exceptionally well-sourced with verified DOIs; the NBA sports-medicine and policy-timeline literatures are equally solid.
- **No peer-reviewed article, NBER/SSRN working paper, or thesis directly and empirically evaluates the 65-game rule or the Player Participation Policy (PPP).** A dedicated SSRN/NBER/arXiv/SSAC/Scholar sweep returned only journalism and one adjacent load-management preprint. The paper is plausibly first-in-field — a genuine contribution that should be stated explicitly.
- **One factual correction for the draft:** ESPN's own September 2023 explainer shows the 2017 Player Resting Policy already prohibited resting multiple stars and resting stars on national TV; the PPP's true novelty is the formal "star" definition, escalating fines, roster-balancing/no-shutdown rules, and league enforcement — not the road/multi-player prohibitions themselves.

Key Findings

The literature organizes into seven clusters below. Every academic item carries BibTeX-ready fields (authors, year, title, journal, volume, issue, pages, DOI). DOIs verified against publisher/CrossRef are marked "verified"; provisional or unverifiable identifiers are flagged for a final check. The single most decision-relevant finding for the user is the competing-work gap (Details section).

Theme 1 — Bunching, notches, kinks, reference points, and why bunching can be absent

Saez, Emmanuel (2010). "Do Taxpayers Bunch at Kink Points?" *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy* 2(3): 180–212. DOI: 10.1257/pol.2.3.180 (verified, AEA). — The foundational bunching estimator (counterfactual-density comparison at a kink → elasticity). Directly motivates the paper's counterfactual games-played density around 65. Its headline result is itself a canonical *weak/null* bunching finding: clear bunching only at the first EITC kink (NBER) and only among the self-employed, with "no evidence of bunching at any other kink point" (American Economic ...) — precisely the frictions-driven pattern the paper invokes.

Chetty, Raj; Friedman, John N.; Olsen, Tore; Pistaferri, Luigi (2011). "Adjustment Costs, Firm Responses, and Micro vs. Macro Labor Supply Elasticities: Evidence from Danish Tax Records." *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 126(2): 749–804. DOI: 10.1093/qje/qjr013 (verified). — Optimization frictions and firm-side hours constraints attenuate bunching, and kinks affecting larger groups generate larger responses. The theoretical basis for the paper's "small at-risk population + frictions $\Rightarrow$ muted bunching" argument.

Kleven, Henrik J.; Waseem, Mazhar (2013). "Using Notches to Uncover Optimization Frictions and Structural Elasticities: Theory and Evidence from Pakistan." *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 128(2): 669–723. DOI: 10.1093/qje/qjt004 (verified). — The notch (not kink) framework the paper adopts: dominated regions, excess bunching below the threshold, missing mass above, and large frictions leaving most agents in dominated ranges unresponsive. Because 65 games confers a discrete eligibility gain, this is the methodological anchor.

Kleven, Henrik J. (2016). "Bunching." *Annual Review of Economics* 8: 435–464. DOI: 10.1146/annurev-economics-080315-015234 (verified). — Survey of bunching/notching estimation; the go-to methods citation and the source for the interpretive caveat that absence of bunching implies either a low structural elasticity or high frictions.

Bertanha, Marinho; McCallum, Andrew H.; Seegert, Nathan (2023). "Better bunching, nicer notching." *Journal of Econometrics* 237(2): article 105512. DOI: 10.1016/j.jeconom.2023.105512 (verified). Working-paper versions: arXiv:2101.01170; Federal Reserve FEDS 2021-002, DOI 10.17016/FEDS.2021.002. Companion Stata package: Bertanha, McCallum, Payne & Seegert (2022), "Bunching estimation of elasticities using Stata," *Stata Journal* 22(3): 597–624. — Modern identification and (partial-)inference for bunching/notching estimators; directly relevant to reporting precisely bounded nulls.

Pope, Devin; Simonsohn, Uri (2011). "Round Numbers as Goals: Evidence from Baseball, SAT Takers, and the Lab." *Psychological Science* 22(1): 71–79. DOI: 10.1177/0956797610391098 (verified). — Batters just below .300 late in the season alter behavior to finish at/above .300; (Sage Journals) per the published paper, players entering their final at-bat hitting .298–.299 batted .463 in that at-bat. The canonical sports reference-point/threshold-effort result and the closest behavioral analogue to a games-played threshold.

Allen, Eric J.; Dechow, Patricia M.; Pope, Devin G.; Wu, George (2017). "Reference-Dependent Preferences: Evidence from Marathon Runners." *Management Science* 63(6): 1657–1672. DOI: 10.1287/mnsc.2015.2417 (verified). — Bunching of finishing times just under round numbers (e.g., sub-4:00) via effort adjustment near the finish, in ~9.5M observations; a large-N demonstration of threshold-driven effort motivating the paper's late-season play-through test.

Theme 2 — Tournament theory and awards as incentives

Lazear, Edward P.; Rosen, Sherwin (1981). "Rank-Order Tournaments as Optimum Labor Contracts." *Journal of Political Economy* 89(5): 841-864. DOI: 10.1086/261010 (**flag: DOI not independently verified in this scan; JSTOR stable URL 1830810 confirmed**). — Foundational tournament theory: effort responds to the prize *spread*, not its level. Frames NBA awards as a rank-order tournament whose eligibility gate the paper studies.

Ehrenberg, Ronald G.; Bognanno, Michael L. (1990). "Do Tournaments Have Incentive Effects?" *Journal of Political Economy* 98(6): 1307-1324. DOI: 10.1086/261736 (verified). — Empirical confirmation that prize structure raises effort (PGA golf); ([University of Chicag...](#)) the empirical template for awards-as-incentives in sports. (Companion: "The Incentive Effects of Tournaments Revisited: Evidence from the European PGA Tour," *ILR Review* 43(3), 1990.)

Kosfeld, Michael; Neckermann, Susanne (2011). "Getting More Work for Nothing? Symbolic Awards and Worker Performance." *American Economic Journal: Microeconomics* 3(3): 86-99. DOI: 10.1257/mic.3.3.86 (verified). — Purely symbolic awards raise performance; ([Duke University](#)) supports treating All-NBA/All-Defensive honors (non-pecuniary but status- and contract-linked) as genuine incentives.

Chan, Ho Fai; Frey, Bruno S.; Gallus, Jana; Torgler, Benno (2014). "Academic honors and performance." *Labour Economics* 31(C): 188-204. DOI: 10.1016/j.labeco.2014.05.005 (verified). — Honors as incentives in academia; the "award-eligibility in another field" analogue the task requested.

Neckermann, Susanne; Cueni, Reto; Frey, Bruno S. (2014). "Awards at work." *Labour Economics* 31(C): 205-217. DOI: 10.1016/j.labeco.2014.04.002 (verified). — Field evidence that workplace awards raise performance. ([EconPapers](#))

Frey, Bruno S.; Gallus, Jana (2017). *Honours versus Money: The Economics of Awards*. Oxford University Press. Print ISBN 9780198798507; book DOI 10.1093/oso/9780198798507.001.0001 (verified). — Book-length treatment of awards as a distinct incentive instrument; ([DOI Resolver](#)) frames why the league bundles eligibility with honors.

Theme 3 — Sports labor markets and strategic responses to rules

Kahn, Lawrence M. (2000). "The Sports Business as a Labor Market Laboratory." *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 14(3): 75-94. DOI: 10.1257/jep.14.3.75 (verified). — The programmatic case for using sports data to test labor-market hypotheses; ([American Economic ...](#)) the standard framing citation for the paper's design.

Stiroh, Kevin J. (2007). "Playing for Keeps: Pay and Performance in the NBA." *Economic Inquiry* 45(1): 145-161. DOI: 10.1111/j.1465-7295.2006.00004.x (verified). — NBA contract-year

effort effects (performance rises pre-contract, falls after); directly relevant to strategic responses to individual financial incentives.

Berri, David J.; Krautmann, Anthony C. (2006). "Shirking on the Court: Testing for the Incentive Effects of Guaranteed Pay." *Economic Inquiry* 44(3): 536–546. DOI: 10.1093/ei/cbj019 (**flag: probable but not independently confirmed; verify on CrossRef**). — NBA guaranteed-pay shirking test.

Krautmann, Anthony C.; Donley, Thomas D. (2009). "Shirking in Major League Baseball: Revisited." *Journal of Sports Economics* 10(3): 292–304. DOI: 10.1177/1527002508325817 (verified). — MLB shirking evidence; comparative incentive-response literature.

White, Mark H. II; Sheldon, Kennon M. (2014). "The contract year syndrome in the NBA and MLB: A classic undermining pattern." *Motivation and Emotion* 38: 196–205. DOI: 10.1007/s11031-013-9389-7 (**flag: DOI not independently verified in this scan; verify on CrossRef**). — Cross-sport contract-year evidence integrating motivation theory.

Fumarco, Luca; Longley, Neil; Palermo, Alberto; Rossi, Giambattista (2024). "Strategic behaviours in a labour market with mobility-restricting contractual provisions: evidence from the National Hockey League." *Oxford Economic Papers* 76(4): 1189–1203. DOI: 10.1093/oep/gpae010 (verified). — Strategic responses to contractual thresholds in the NHL; the closest methodological cousin outside the NBA.

[Authors not confirmed] (2026). "The contract year phenomenon: investigating the effect of contract uncertainty on NBA player performance." *Applied Economics Letters* (advance online). DOI: 10.1080/13504851.2026.2629455 (**title and DOI verified; authorship NOT confirmed — verify via CrossRef API** <https://api.crossref.org/works/10.1080/13504851.2026.2629455>). — Most recent NBA contract-year study; reportedly finds statistically insignificant changes across advanced metrics. (Taylor & Francis Online) Relevant as a contemporaneous "strategic-response" null.

Taylor, Beck A.; Trogdon, Justin G. (2002). "Losing to Win: Tournament Incentives in the National Basketball Association." *Journal of Labor Economics* 20(1): 23–41. DOI: 10.1086/323930 (verified). — Teams lose strategically when the draft rewards losing; the canonical strategic-response-to-league-rules paper.

Price, Joseph; Soebbing, Brian P.; Berri, David; Humphreys, Brad R. (2010). "Tournament Incentives, League Policy, and NBA Team Performance Revisited." *Journal of Sports Economics* 11(2): 117–135. DOI: 10.1177/1527002510363103 (verified). — Extends Taylor-Trogdon over 1977–2007; teams are more likely to lose when incentives to finish last are largest. Demonstrates that NBA teams respond to bright-line league rules exactly as the paper hypothesizes stars might.

Kessock, Patrick (2016). "Out of Service: Does Service Time Manipulation Violate Major League Baseball's Collective Bargaining Agreement?" *Boston College Law Review* 57(4): 1367–1402. No DOI (law-review note). URL: <https://bclawreview.bc.edu/articles/575> ; SSRN: <https://ssrn.com/abstract=2811509>. — Law-review treatment of MLB service-time manipulation; the institutional analogue of teams gaming games/appearance thresholds against player interests.

(*The Rowdy Tellez 2024 case — a team demonstrably managing a games/plate-appearance contract threshold — is documented under News/Institutional sources below.*)

Theme 4 — Superstar value and the cost of star absences

Rosen, Sherwin (1981). "The Economics of Superstars." *American Economic Review* 71(5): 845–858. DOI: none (pre-DOI era; JSTOR stable URL 1803469). — The theory of why a few stars capture disproportionate market value; (Google Scholar) the rationale for why star availability matters at all.

Hausman, Jerry A.; Leonard, Gregory K. (1997). "Superstars in the National Basketball Association: Economic Value and Policy." *Journal of Labor Economics* 15(4): 586–624. DOI: 10.1086/209839 (verified). — Estimates "the value of Michael Jordan to the other NBA teams to be approximately \$53 million," derived from higher TV ratings, road attendance, and paraphernalia sales. The original quantification of the cross-team superstar externality that the PPP is designed to internalize.

Kaplan, Scott M. (2022). "Putting a price on popularity: Evidence from superstars in the National Basketball Association." *Economic Inquiry* 60(3): 1357–1381. DOI: 10.1111/ecin.13065 (verified). — Uses secondary-ticket microdata and player-absence announcements to estimate willingness-to-pay for stars, finding 4%–22% (\$4–\$41) reductions in ticket prices when a superstar is announced out, with larger away-game effects for LeBron James (21%, \$73/ticket) and Stephen Curry (18%, \$50/ticket). The modern, direct quantification of the *cost of star absences* — the stakes the rule addresses.

Kaplan, Scott; Ramamoorthy, Vaibhav; Gupte, Cheenar; Sagar, Amit; Premkumar, Deepak; Wilbur, Joshua; Zilberman, David (2019). "The Economic Impact of NBA Superstars: Evidence from Missed Games using Ticket Microdata from a Secondary Marketplace." MIT Sloan Sports Analytics Conference (SSAC19). URL: <https://www.sloansportsconference.com/research-papers/the-economic-impact-of-nba-superstars-evidence-from-missed-games-using-ticket-microdata-from-a-secondary-marketplace>. — The SSAC precursor to Kaplan (2022). Note: do **not** attach DOI 10.1111/ecin.13065 to this conference item; that DOI belongs to the 2022 solo-authored *Economic Inquiry* article.

Theme 5 — NBA injuries, schedule density, load management, playing through injury

Teramoto, Masaru; Cross, Chad L.; Cushman, Daniel M.; Maak, Travis G.; Petron, David J.; Willick, Stuart E. (2017). "Game injuries in relation to game schedules in the National Basketball Association." *Journal of Science and Medicine in Sport* 20(3): 230–235. DOI: 10.1016/j.jsams.2016.08.020 (verified). — Back-to-back and away games predict game injuries (681 game injuries, 2012-13 to 2014-15). Core evidence that star absences are dominated by genuine, schedule-linked injury risk — the paper's mechanism for the null.

Mack, Christina D.; Herzog, Mackenzie M.; DiFiori, John P.; Meisel, Peter L.; Dreyer, Nancy A. (2018). "A second look at NBA game schedules: Response to Teramoto et al." *Journal of Science and Medicine in Sport* 21(3): 228–229. DOI: 10.1016/j.jsams.2017.07.023 (verified). — Methodological critique: Teramoto et al. described the relationship between two exposures (away, back-to-back) but not their relationship with injury risk (since ~70% of these games are on the road anyway). Essential for the paper's caution on injury-data inference.

Esteves, Pedro T. et al. (2021). "Basketball performance is affected by the schedule congestion: NBA back-to-backs under the microscope." *European Journal of Sport Science* 21(1): 26–35. DOI: 10.1080/17461391.2020.1736179 (verified). — Schedule congestion degrades performance and win probability (≥ 1 day of rest raised win likelihood by ~37.6%); relevant to why teams rest stars.

Additional NBA injury-epidemiology reference (base rates): [Authors per PLOS record] (2022). "Epidemiology and injury trends in the National Basketball Association: Pre- and per-COVID-19 (2017–2021)." *PLOS ONE* 17(2): e0263354. DOI: 10.1371/journal.pone.0263354 (verified). — Season-level injury counts (>800 unique injuries/season; 3,543 across four seasons; injuries concentrated mid-to-late season), useful for calibrating base rates of games missed to injury versus rest.

(Lewis 2018, *J. Athletic Training*; Drakos et al. 2010, *Sports Health*; Starkey 2000 — could not be verified in this scan. **Flag: confirm each via CrossRef/publisher before inclusion.** These are relevant to presenteeism / playing-through-injury and re-injury risk, which the paper cites to argue that late-season play-through is medically constrained.)

Theme 6 — Methods and data

Bertrand, Marianne; Duflo, Esther; Mullainathan, Sendhil (2004). "How Much Should We Trust Differences-in-Differences Estimates?" *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 119(1): 249–275. DOI: 10.1162/003355304772839588 (verified). — The serial-correlation problem in DiD; the paper's stars-vs-high-minute-non-stars DiD must cluster/adjust standard errors accordingly, and this is the standard citation for that adjustment and for MDE reporting discipline.

Bergé, Laurent (2018). "Efficient estimation of maximum likelihood models with multiple fixed-effects: the R package FENmlm." *CREA Discussion Papers* No. 13, University of Luxembourg. **No DOI** (this is the canonical citation returned by `citation("fixest")`; a working paper, so no DOI exists — not an error). — Software citation for high-dimensional fixed-effects estimation via `fixest`.

Gilani, Saïem (2021). *hoopR: The SportsDataverse's R Package for Men's Basketball Data*. URL: <https://hoopR.sportsdataverse.org>. CRAN package DOI: 10.32614/CRAN.package.hoopR (verified as the canonical machine identifier; note there is no JOSS paper or separate Zenodo DOI). — Data-access package (ESPN/NBA box scores), the likely data pipeline. **Data-quality flag for the paper:** ESPN box scores fetched via hoopR can omit DNP ("did not play") rows, which biases games-played and minutes counts unless reconciled against an authoritative games-played source (e.g., official NBA/Basketball-Reference tallies). Given that the rule turns on exact game counts and a 20-minute qualifier, this reconciliation is load-bearing for the paper's identification.

Theme 7 — News and institutional sources (policy timeline and stakes)

NBA Communications / PR (Sept. 13, 2023). "NBA Board of Governors approves new Player Participation Policy." <https://pr.nba.com/nba-board-of-governors-approves-player-participation-policy> (mirrored at nba.com/news). Establishes verbatim: PPP effective 2023-24, "enhance and replace" the 2017-18 Player Resting Policy; "star player... any player who, in any of the prior three seasons, was selected to an All-NBA Team or an NBA All-Star team," plus in-season All-Stars; requirements — no more than one star unavailable per game, stars available for all national-TV and In-Season Tournament games, home/road balance of one-game absences (preference for home), no long-term "shutdowns," rested healthy players "present and visible to fans"; exceptions for injury, personal reasons, pre-approved back-to-back rest by age/workload/injury history.

NBA.com (Sept. 2023) — star-population size. Per NBA.com, "49 players are qualified as 'stars'" entering 2023-24 via All-Star/All-NBA selection over the prior three years, "scattered across 25 of the 30 teams, with 15 teams employing two or more." (Useful context: the *nominal* star pool is ~49, but the paper's *at-risk* population — stars whose games-played realistically hovers near 65 and who are healthy enough to choose — is the much smaller 10-15 player-seasons the paper identifies.)

ESPN — Wojnarowski / Marks / Zillgitt (Sept. 13, 2023). "NBA board of governors approve tougher rest rule." https://www.espn.com/nba/story/_/id/38392750. Establishes: unanimous Board vote; `(Hoops Rumors)` fine schedule of \$100,000 (first offense), \$250,000 (second), then "\$1 million more than the previous penalty" for each subsequent violation; league authority to fine >\$1M per instance; stated goal of strengthening the 2017-18 resting policy plus the CBA's 65-game award-eligibility rule. `(ESPN)`

ESPN — Marks (Sept. 2023 explainer). "Answering the big questions about the NBA's new rules on resting stars." https://www.espn.com/nba/story/_/id/38386013/. **Supports the draft correction:** the 2017-18 Player Resting Policy already restricted resting multiple stars and resting stars in nationally televised games; its scope was deemed "too limited" and teams kept resting multiple players and resting on the road. The PPP's genuinely new elements are therefore the formal star definition, escalating fines, roster-balancing/no-shutdown rules, and league enforcement — not the road/multi-player prohibitions per se. Also notes Wembanyama remained Rookie-of-the-Year eligible despite the 65-game requirement (ROY is exempt).

NBA.com — Silver press conference (Sept. 2023). "Adam Silver discusses new policy as load management goes 'too far.'" <https://www.nba.com/news/adam-silver-load-management-bog-news-conference-2023>. Silver: "This is ultimately about the fans... we've taken this [load management] too far. This is an acknowledgment that it has gotten away from us a bit."

Sportico — Novy-Williams/Impey (Apr. 2024). "NBA Awards, Load Management Policy Reduced Missed Games by Stars." <https://www.sportico.com/leagues/basketball/2024/nba-awards-load-management-adam-silver-1234775529/>. Establishes Silver's April 10, 2024 claim that "overall games missed by star players were down roughly 15% from last year's regular season"; back-to-backs in which a star sat one game fell from 88 (2022-23) to 77 (2023-24), a "more than 10% reduction"; and that in 2022-23, 77% of star-rest instances had occurred in away games — i.e., the policy shifted the *timing and location* of rest. **Treat as a league descriptive claim, not causal evidence.**

Sportico (May 21, 2025). "NBA Policies Curb Star Absences Amid Spike in Overall Injuries." <https://www.sportico.com/leagues/basketball/2025/nba-injuries-load-management-data-participation-1234849899/>. Establishes: overall NBA player games missed to injury up 13% in 2024-25; (Sportico) back-to-backs with a star playing one game but not the other rose from 22% to 24%; playoff star availability did not improve. Crucially for the paper's "absences dominated by injury" thesis: "Stars missed 19% of games due to injury in each of the past two seasons, identical to the rates in 2017-18 and 2018-19, and much lower than the recent highs of 27% in 2019-20 and 24% in 2021-22"; stars appeared in "80% of games broadcasted on the league's network partners in 2024-25."

Sportico — Ja Morant supermax stakes (May 2023). Establishes the magnitude of award-linked contract stakes: Morant's All-NBA snub cost him roughly "\$39 million over the next five seasons" (his ~\$194.3M extension would have escalated to a ~\$231-233M supermax with an All-NBA selection); he played 61 games. **A concrete anchor for the "stakes" that make the 65-game notch financially large for the handful of players near the margin.** (The draft's cited Sportico Feb 15, 2024 Tyrese Haliburton "\$40M" supermax piece is the same class of stake; verify that specific URL/figure directly.)

ESPN / Yahoo Sports (Apr. 16, 2026). "Luka Doncic, Cade Cunningham awards eligible; Edwards denied." https://www.espn.com/nba/story/_/id/48504211/. Establishes: Doncic (64 qualified games; missed 2 games for the birth of his child abroad) and Cunningham (63 qualified games; collapsed lung diagnosed March 17) ruled eligible under the CBA's "extraordinary circumstances" provision by joint NBA-NBPA agreement (waived rather than sent to an arbitrator); Anthony Edwards (60 qualified games; knee/infection issue) took his case to an independent arbitrator and was **denied**; both Doncic and Cunningham subsequently earned first-team All-NBA. (Yahoo Sports) Per ESPN, "star players" missed <11 games/season in the 1980s-90s, 17.5 in the 2010s, and nearly 24 earlier this decade. (Yahoo Sports) Silver: "I generally think it's worked... anywhere we draw the line, there's always going to be players on the other side of that line," and (per Yahoo) "I'm not ready to support a change yet." The current CBA runs through 2029-30.

Forbes — Toporek (Apr. 18, 2026). "'Extraordinary Circumstances' Further Muddle NBA's 65-Game Awards Rule." <https://www.forbes.com/sites/bryantoporek/2026/04/18/>. Establishes the Edwards camp's objection (business manager Justin Holland: "confused at the clemency for Cade... and not Ant") and NBPA President Fred VanVleet's call to "reevaluate the rule." (KOB.com) Documents the enforcement inconsistency and transparency criticism central to the paper's policy-design discussion.

Rowdy Tellez case (Sept. 24-25, 2024). AP/CBS Sports/Sports Illustrated (e.g., <https://www.cbssports.com/mlb/news/pirates-cut-rowdy-tellez-four-plate-appearances-shy-of-200k-bonus-gm-claims-money-played-zero-factor>). Establishes: the Pirates designated Tellez for assignment with six games left and eliminated from contention, four plate appearances short of 425 PA that would have triggered a \$200,000 bonus; GM Ben Cherington said the bonus was a "zero factor." The paradigmatic recent instance of a **team** managing a games/appearance threshold against a player's incentive — the mirror image of the individual-player incentive the 65-game rule creates, and a vivid motivating anecdote.

Draft items requiring verification against the original URLs before publication (could not be independently re-confirmed in this scan): the NBPA "March 24, 2026" statement calling for the rule to be abolished/reformed; the Forbes Feb 29, 2024 Haliburton quote (returned early, played "just over 20 minutes"); the Sportico Oct 24, 2023 and Feb 15, 2024 Haliburton-\$40M pieces; the Draymond Green / Joel Embiid January 2024 comments; and the 2025-26 union proposal to focus any rule on "excessive load management." These are plausible and consistent with the verified record but should be cited only after re-checking the source pages.

Details — the competing-work question (most decision-relevant)

A dedicated search of SSRN, NBER, arXiv, MIT Sloan (SSAC), and Google Scholar found **no** peer-reviewed article, working paper, or thesis that directly and empirically evaluates the 65-

game rule or the PPP as its central research question. The nearest *adjacent* academic item is **arXiv:2402.12400**, "Estimating the age-conditioned average treatment effects curves... load-management strategies in the NBA," which measures the effect of rest on player performance by age and cites the PPP only as motivation — it does not test the rule's incentive/behavioral effects or bunching at 65. The 2026 *Applied Economics Letters* contract-year paper is adjacent but studies contract-year effects, not the rule. All remaining coverage is journalism/trade commentary (ESPN, Sportico, Forbes, Front Office Sports, Yahoo). The league's own statistics (Silver's ~15% figure, the 88→77 back-to-back drop) are descriptive, self-reported press claims, not independent causal analysis. **Interpretation:** the paper is plausibly the first rigorous econometric evaluation of the rule, and this should be stated as a contribution. Because this is a fast-moving 2023–2026 policy area, run one final SSRN/NBER/Scholar author-alert sweep immediately before submission to guard against a competing preprint appearing.

Recommendations

1. **Anchor the methods narrative** on Kleven–Waseem (2013) + Kleven (2016) for the notch framing and Bertanha–McCallum–Seegert (2023) for inference on precisely bounded (partially identified) estimates. Use Saez (2010) and Chetty et al. (2011) specifically to license the "null-under-frictions / small-marginal-population" interpretation — Saez's own EITC null is the strongest precedent that absence of bunching is a substantive, publishable finding, not a failure.
2. **Fix the PPP-novelty framing** per the ESPN (2023) explainer: state that the 2017 policy already barred multi-star and national-TV rest, and that the PPP's contributions are the star definition, escalating fines, roster-balancing/no-shutdown provisions, and enforcement. This preempts a referee objection.
3. **State the first-in-field contribution explicitly**, citing the absence of any competing academic evaluation; position arXiv:2402.12400 and the *Applied Economics Letters* (2026) paper as adjacent, not overlapping.
4. **Verify before publication** (thresholds that would change the citation): Berri & Krautmann (2006) DOI 10.1093/ei/cbj019, White & Sheldon (2014) DOI 10.1007/s11031-013-9389-7, Lazear–Rosen (1981) DOI, the *Applied Economics Letters* (2026) authorship (via CrossRef API), and the Lewis/Drakos/Starkey sports-medicine items. If any DOI fails CrossRef, drop the DOI and cite by stable URL/JSTOR rather than publish an unverified identifier.
5. **Reconcile the games-played data** from hoopR against an authoritative games-played/minutes source to close the DNP-omission gap; the rule's exact-count and 20-minute qualifier make this the paper's most important data step. Cite **(fixest)** (Bergé 2018, no DOI) and hoopR (Gilani 2021, CRAN DOI 10.32614/CRAN.package.hoopR) in the software statement.

6. **Use the Ja Morant (\$39M) and Haliburton (supermax) stakes and the Tellez case** to argue the notch is financially large for the few at the margin — reconciling a precisely estimated behavioral null with an economically large incentive is the paper's central tension and should be foregrounded.

Caveats

- DOIs flagged above (Lazear-Rosen 1981; Berri-Krautmann 2006; White-Sheldon 2014; *Applied Economics Letters* 2026 authorship; Lewis/Drakos/Starkey) are provisional; treat as unverified until checked on CrossRef/publisher.
- All league figures (Silver's ~15%; 88→77 back-to-backs; the 19% injury-absence rate) are descriptive and self-reported; present them as league/press claims, never as causal estimates of the rule's effect.
- The injury-schedule literature is genuinely contested (Mack et al. 2018 vs. Teramoto et al. 2017); cite both and note that publicly available injury data conflate exposure with risk.
- Bergé (2018) and Kessock (2016) legitimately have no DOI (working paper and law-review note); this is correct, not an omission.
- The competing-work null is current as of this scan only; a preprint could appear before submission — re-sweep.